

ACT I

INT. BAKERY - DAWN

...an "8" piped in white icing on a cake. A BAKER places fresh fruits on top.

EXT. FISH MARKET RESTAURANT - CONTINUOUS

Outside the bakery window, CÁT (32) and her daughter ACADIA TRAN (8) sit at a table across the street by a restaurant.

The camera looks down at the table, focusing on a paper placemat, featuring twelve zodiac animals with their respective years. The Tiger and "2034" is in the center.

An untouched bowl of PHO sits on Acadia's side. Cát's side is littered with empty plates of fishes, crabs, and mollusk shells. Their leaf hats lean against the table legs.

Cát pulls Acadia closer for a selfie and holds up the placemat. Acadia is grumpy.

SNAP.

Cát looks at her phone. She places the photo in a digital album titled "Sinh nhat cua Cadi."

SUBTITLE: Cadi's birthday

Cát scrolls through past photos. All at the same table, taken yearly with Cát holding placemats with animals of the year descending from 2034 to 2027 (when Acadia was one). The 2027 photo shows them with an Indonesian man in a U.S. Coast Guard shirt. *Le khai truong / Grand opening* ribbons hang around.

Cát sighs, with anguish clouding her.

YOUNG ACADIA

Nhìn gì, mẹ?

(What are you looking at, mom?)

CÁT

(Snapping back to reality)

Nothing. You- you still have so much in your bowl.

YOUNG ACADIA

I'm not hungry.

CÁT

Empty stomach, empty head.

YOUNG ACADIA

And you have a big belly.

Cát looks insulted.

ACADIA

So big brained.

Cát picks up some chopsticks and points them at the contents of the pho bowl: slices of beef, rice noodles, green herbs.

CÁT

Fine. If it gets you to eat, I'll show you what's been on my mind.

She points the chopsticks at the tiny, floating beef slices.

CÁT (CONT'D)

There are 367 islands...

She points to one large, single piece of beef.

CÁT (CONT'D)

...off the coast of Vietnam...

She dramatically twirls noodles between the beefy "islands."

CÁT (CONT'D)

...and a whirlpool that hides...

She uses a spoon to raise a bone fragment from the broth.

CÁT (CONT'D)

...our ancestral island.

She shoves the spoon into Acadia's open mouth.

MONTAGE.

Vietnamese puppetry paints a picture for the sequence.

YOUNG ACADIA (V.O.)

(Mouth full, disgusted)

Ew! Mom! That's a bone-

Puppet Acadia spits out Fossil Island.

CÁT (V.O.)

Exactly. The bone is Fossil Island.
It's a spiritual place where we can
reconnect with lost family members.
They live among horseshoe spirits.

Glowing, blue-blooded horseshoe crab puppets appear.

YOUNG ACADIA (V.O.)
Horseshoe crabs are invertebrates?

CÁT (V.O.)
I never said they had bones. Their
life force is actually in their
blue blood, which heals wounds.

YOUNG ACADIA (V.O.)
What if you lose an arm? Does it
grow back?

CÁT (V.O.)
Wow. A sick sense of humor like me.

The crabs are snatched by shadowy puppets holding syringes.

CÁT (V.O.)
But such power makes them a target.
Our island must be kept secret from
outsiders who want to exploit the
blood for their own selfish gain.

Fossil Island gets hidden within the hundreds of islands.

CÁT (V.O.)
This island goes way deeper than
bones and blood. It's our SOULS.
This was where me, my mom, my
grandfather, his mother, her mom,
every generation before us... This
was where we were born.

YOUNG ACADIA (V.O.)
And I was born on mainland...

We travel to mainland Vietnam.

CÁT (V.O.)
Maine.

Then we go all the way to Maine in the United States.

YOUNG ACADIA (V.O.)
Why wasn't I born on Fossil Island?

CÁT (V.O.)
I loved someone far away very much.
I met him in my exchange program
during a dark time in Maine. If I
left, I may never see him again.

Puppet Cát looks sadly at a puppet man in naval uniform.

YOUNG ACADIA (V.O.)

Dad?

CÁT (V.O.)

We didn't see eye to eye at first,
an island there made us put our
differences aside.

Puppet Cát and the naval puppet hold baby puppet Acadia.

CÁT (V.O.)

The law kept us apart. We thought
having you on Relic Island might
keep us together. It didn't work.

MILITANT PUPPETS gather puppet Cát and her baby, and other
puppets onto a boat to Vietnam. They are the inverse
Vietnamese boat people.

CÁT (V.O.)

I became the only option for you.
And now you're here.

Puppet Cát holds a baby puppet Acadia.

BACK TO REALITY.

EXT. FISH MARKET RESTAURANT - CONTINUOUS

Acadia is playing with the bone she spit out earlier.

CÁT

I'll bring you the whole world.
I'll bring you algae. I'll bring
you mollusk shells. I'll bring you
clams. I'll bring you fishes,
CRABS! I'll bring you everything
but...

ACADIA & CÁT

...peace...

They giggle together.

The WAITER comes out and places the bill on the table.

WAITER

(in Vietnamese; subtitled)
*Sorry to disturb the peace. How was
everything?*

The waiter sees that Acadia's bowl is untouched.

WAITER (CONT'D)

You haven't touched your pho?

The waiter neighs like a horse, pointing to the placemat.

WAITER (CONT'D)

*Them things make me so hungry, I
could eat a horse in my pho!*

Acadia walks off, unamused.

WAITER (CONT'D)

*Ah, come on. It's an expression!
Horse ain't on the menu. It's on
request... What grade is she now?*

CÁT

*(in Vietnamese; subtitled)
7th grade. She's four years ahead.*

WAITER

Teen or genius, they love horses.

CÁT

*She's never been a horse girl like
the other school kids...*

CUTAWAY TO:

EXT. KINDERGARTEN CLASSROOM - DAY

The classroom wall is covered with drawings of horses. Four-year-old Acadia hangs her platypus drawing. A KID mocks it.

KID

*(in Vietnamese; subtitled)
That's an ugly-looking horse.*

YOUNG ACADIA

*(in Vietnamese; subtitled)
He's a platypus! And every platypus
are beautiful.*

RETURN TO:

By the fish market, Acadia stares at a tank of seahorses.

WAITER

She's more of a seahorse girl.

The waiter walks away, proud of their pun.

CÁT

Only the open sea lands with her.

Cát opens an email app on her phone.

CÁT (CONT'D)

Cadi! How you like them seahorses?!

Acadia heads back to Cát.

YOUNG ACADIA

They're cooler in water than land.

CÁT

Well, I'm a 2002 water horse.

Cát gets a pen and circles 2002 by the HORSE on the placemat.

YOUNG ACADIA

You're an old horse. I'm the newest-

Acadia nabs the pen and circles 2026 by the HORSE.

The BAKER from earlier hands them the cake in a ribbon box.

CÁT

Look who's talking, my fire horse.

YOUNG ACADIA

Cake! It's not super sweet, right?

CÁT

You know it. And here's the icing on the cake: I told your teacher you're not feeling well. Cool of me, huh? *Question mark?*

YOUNG ACADIA

Not real- I'm not really sick-
Well, on second thought-

Acadia takes Cát's phone and boots up *Animal Crossing*.

Cát takes back her phone. She places cash on the bill.

CÁT

Let's spend today horsing around.

YOUNG ACADIA

Don't you have a job?

CÁT

I also called out sick.

YOUNG ACADIA

But you're not sick!

CÁT

I'm sick of my boss.

The waiter takes back the bill without the cash.

WAITER

(in Vietnamese; subtitled)

*A boss always finds out. I would
know. The food's on me just in case
you lose your job.*

The waiter heads back into the restaurant.

CÁT

My child...

Cát and Acadia wear their leaf hats, take their cake, and get on their motorcycle. It ramps up and they drive off.

EXT. LAN HA BAY - CLIFFSIDE - MIDMORNING

Cát and Acadia park the motorcycle by a cliffside overlooking the Pacific Ocean. The beach has a port with several motorboats and a single motorized sailboat.

CÁT

Today is the gift of a lifetime!

Acadia slides down the cliffside and lands in the sand. Cát cautiously follows. They go to the port.

EXT. LAN HA BAY - PORT - CONTINUOUS

YOUNG ACADIA

Am I getting swimming lessons?

CÁT

Not from this water horse, not from
the seahorses, the horseshoes!

YOUNG ACADIA

Horseshoes?

They reach a weathered sailboat, the name *VAST* etched on its hull. Cát helps Acadia into the boat. She then steps in and pulls out a ring of keys. She uses a *VAST* key to open a compartment to activate the red sails and ramp up the motor.

They sail away from the mainland.